

Customised USB hubs

Everyone has probably had their fill of crazy looking flash drives. Now check out some crazy USB hubs
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Bacteria good for computers

Researchers says that magnetic bacteria can help in making bio-computers in the future
<http://dgit.in/JOfnzK>

Something missing on most ultrabooks is a satisfactorily big cooling vent, something the XPS 13 does very well. It shows as well, because this one doesn't become as warm and noisy as some of the other ultrabooks after an hour of usage.

The **Samsung Series 5** uses a lid colour shade similar to Dell's XPS 13. The grey matte aluminium finish doesn't catch fingerprints, dust and scratches like glossy surfaces do. The rarely-used-on-ultrabooks optical drive is placed on the right side, and even that has a dual-layered design. Placement could have been better. Try picking up the laptop and you risk accidentally popping it open. On the opposite side are two USB 3.0 ports, an HDMI, Ethernet and even a VGA port as well as a combined port for headphone and mic. We were surprised by the quality of materials and the overall finish of the Series 5 – much better than expected.

Acer's Aspire S3 is the least expensive ultrabook around. Brushed metal finish on the lid is the first element pointing to that. Open it, and you'll notice that the colour combination is off. The grey finish is matched with a different (lighter as well)

shade from the same colour family, and it looks plastic, while in reality it actually isn't! The power button looks at you from just below the display, on the hinge shell – a unique place to put the power key. All ports are placed on the rear, taking advantage of all that space thanks to the display hinge mechanism. This leaves the sides looking very slim and clean, except a camouflaged card reader on one side and a 3.5mm jack on the other.

The **ASUS Zenbook UX31E** faces the same allegations as the Dell XPS 13 – it looks too similar to the MacBook Air. However, this 13-inch ultrabook has a finish like no other ultrabook in this test – its brushed metallic unibody design makes sure of that. It's one of the slimmest ultrabooks around, but still can't pip the MacBook Air 13. The Zenbook weighs 1.3 kg, and is lighter than the HP Folio 13, Samsung Series 5, the Acer Aspire S3 and Lenovo IdeaPad U300s. Keep sharp objects away from it, because it gets scratched easily. This is also the most expensive ultrabook in the test, and the build quality justifies that to a large extent.

Lenovo's IdeaPad U300s has a whole dollop of premium feel to it, something that surpasses the likes of the HP Folio 13. Another design highlight of the IdeaPad U300s is its all over consistent thickness – unlike the ASUS Zenbook UX31E or the Dell XPS 13 or the Apple MacBook Air 13 (All three of these ultrabooks are thicker at the hinges and thinner at the front edge). The IdeaPad U300s weighs and is just



Samsung Series 5 ultrabook

pipped by the Asus Zenbook (1.3 kg) to the finish line on that one. It has a polished metal exterior that's durable and robust on touch, and hinges that fuse the keyboard deck with the screen efficiently. The IdeaPad U300s' screen though might be a tad too thin, as it wobbles whenever you try to adjust the screen angle before coming to a quick rest.

HP's Folio has a brushed metal screen lid made of aluminum and coated with a classy tinge of champagne brown. Prop it open to reveal the same colour scheme and surface encasing the black keyboard deck. The HP Folio 13 is very well built. Touch and feel the HP ultrabook's surface and you feel you're interacting with a premium product. The only disappointment is its plastic bottom panel.

The **Toshiba Portege Z830** has a true ultrabook form factor, and so it isn't a surprise that this magnesium alloy chassis draped machine is by far the lightest ultrabook we've tested so far. Call it finding a niche amidst a niche. All ports are on the rear panel. What the left side spine does have is the dual side jack combo for a headphone and mic, and an SD card reader. The right spine has the lone USB 3.0 port. The brushed metal finish

of the lid looks classy, and the same theme continues for the palm rest and the area around the keyboard. Appreciate the generous real estate space on the touchpad, but the fingerprint sensor separates right-click and left-click keys, and a bunch of LEDs also get added into the mix. If you place the Portege Z830 on your lap and are typing out a document, you'll notice a very annoying display vibration at times – that's because the hinge isn't very taut. If you push the display a little further back, the problem considerably reduces. But at the optimum display angle, you'll ideally have to type less furiously! Despite using all the right materials and ideas, the Portege Z830 doesn't feel as premium as it should.

Wipro also jumped on the ultrabook wagon with the e.go Aero, but it doesn't feel premium in any way and leaves you with a sense of incompleteness.

FEATURES & PERFORMANCE

The Acer Aspire S3 has very humble performance figures. The display is reflective, but adequately bright and crisp to negate some of the reflections. It has a 500GB hard drive, something only the Wipro Aero matches, albeit they aren't SSDs.

The Asus Zenbook has the most powerful processor so it's surprising to find it being eclipsed by the likes of the Dell XPS 13, Lenovo IdeaPad U300s, HP Folio and Toshiba Portege.

Testing the Dell XPS 13 was an experience in itself. What was most surprising was the drive copy speeds. The keypad has a tinge of uniqueness to it – the keys are wider than standard keys. The touchpad is a bit iffy at times in terms of



Toshiba Portege Z830